

Have something done

A Study this example situation:



LISA

The roof of Lisa's house was damaged in a storm. So she called a builder, and yesterday a man came and repaired it.

Lisa **had** the roof **repaired** yesterday.

This means: Lisa arranged for somebody else to repair the roof. She didn't repair it herself.

We use **have something done** to say that we arrange for somebody else to do something for us. Compare:

- ☐ Lisa **repaired** the roof. (= she repaired it herself)
- Lisa **had** the roof **repaired**. (= she arranged for somebody else to repair it)
- ☐ 'Did you **make** those curtains yourself?' 'Yes, I enjoy making things.'
- 'Did you **have** those curtains **made**?' 'No, I made them myself.'

B Be careful with word order. The *past participle* (**repaired/cut** etc.) is after the *object*:

have	object	past participle
Lisa had	the roof	repaired yesterday.
Where did you have	your hair	cut ?
Your hair looks nice. Have you had	it	cut ?
Our neighbour has just had	a garage	built .
We are having	the house	painted this week.
How often do you have	your car	serviced ?
I think you should have	that coat	cleaned .
I don't like having	my picture	taken .

C Get something done

You can also say '**get** something done' instead of '**have** something done':

- ☐ When are you going to **get the roof repaired**? (= have the roof repaired)
- ☐ I think you should **get your hair cut** really short.

D Sometimes **have something done** has a different meaning. For example:
☐ Paul and Karen **had their bags stolen** while they were travelling.

This does not mean that they arranged for somebody to steal their bags. 'They **had their bags stolen**' means only: 'Their bags were stolen'.

With this meaning, we use **have something done** to say that something happens to somebody or their belongings. Often what happens is not nice:

- ☐ Gary **had** his nose **broken** in a fight. (= his nose was broken)
- ☐ Have you ever **had** your bike **stolen**?

Exercises

46.1 Tick (✓) the correct sentence, (a) or (b), for each picture.



SARAH

- (a) Sarah is cutting her hair.
(b) Sarah is having her hair cut.



BILL

- (a) Bill is cutting his hair.
(b) Bill is having his hair cut.



JOHN

- (a) John is cleaning his shoes.
(b) John is having his shoes cleaned.



SUE

- (a) Sue is taking a picture.
(b) Sue is having her picture taken.

46.2 Put the words in the correct order.

- had / a few weeks ago / the house / we / painted
We had the house painted a few weeks ago.
- serviced / her car / Sarah / once a year / has
Sarah
- twelve pounds / have / cleaned / it / my suit / cost / to
.....
- my eyes / I / two years ago / had / tested / the last time / was
.....
- had / in the kitchen / fitted / some new cupboards / we've
.....
- as soon as possible / need / translated / we / to get / this document
.....

46.3 Write sentences in the way shown.

- Lisa didn't repair the roof herself. She had it repaired.
- I didn't cut my hair myself. I
- We didn't clean the carpets ourselves. We
- John didn't build that wall himself.
- I didn't deliver the flowers myself.

46.4 Use the words in brackets to complete the sentences. Use the structure **have something done**.

- We're having the house painted. (we / the house / paint) this week.
- I lost my key. I'll have to (another key / make).
- When was the last time (you / your hair / cut)?
- (you / a newspaper / deliver) to your house every day, or do you go out and buy one?
- A: What's happening in your garden?
B: Oh, (we / a garage / build).
- A: (you / the washing machine / fix)?
B: Not yet. There's someone coming to look at it next week.
- If you want to wear earrings, why don't you (you / your ears / pierce)?

Now use '**have something done**' with its second meaning (see Section D).

- Gary was in a fight last night. He had his nose broken. (he / his nose / break).
- Did I tell you about Jane? (she / her credit cards / steal).
- Security was very strict at the airport. (we all / our bags / search).